

Family MATTERS

The story of India's junior Australian Open champ is also the tale of a resilient tennis clan

By Sharda Ugra

The world's No. 1 tennis junior needs to get fat. Okay, okay not non-sporty fat, but more er... substantial. Muscular. With biceps and deltoids that cause T-shirts to involuntarily rip themselves in awe. Yuki Bhambri, 16, may be more stringbean than Schwarzenegger today but he's got a substantial silver trophy on his arm. It's the Australian Open junior boys singles title which carries its own weight: the last time any Indian won anything like it was 19 years ago. When Bhambri was... well, never mind.

Fresh from winning the Australian Open juniors, Bhambri, newly-ranked junior world No. 1, is on his home court at Delhi's Siri Fort complex getting a skin fold test done to check if he's lost any weight. Every ounce will matter. This is the year he plans to graduate onto the men's circuit, (and compete only in the junior Slams). He will need heft to survive in adult company and must get bigger, stronger, faster.

But the 6 ft, 65 kg stringbean feels neither rushed nor under scrutiny. He knows that dizzying ascents take their own toll. Last year, he shot through four inches in height and his growing

pains didn't merely consist of adolescent angst—they were real and he felt them in his knees. He could still gain a few inches more and his team is keeping close, almost paranoid, watch. Because where he belongs, it is as if he has always been chosen. Chosen, it seems, by no less a mysterious entity than the forces of destiny.

Bhambri is the youngest of three tennis-playing children of a middle-class Delhi family. His pathologist father Chander ran a clinic and mom Indu was a regular mother until a decade ago when they accidentally fell under tennis' seductive spell. For